also conducts multilateral surveillance, publishing reports that assess economic trends and risks. Engagement with the IMF, particularly through its conditional lending programs, is both highly public and politically sensitive. These programs impose stringent conditions on borrowing countries in exchange for financial support, often requiring significant policy adjustments that can incur steep domestic costs.

For populist leaders who often reject IOs in their rhetoric and portray them as encroaching on national sovereignty, these costs are particularly problematic. Public engagement with the IMF through loan programs can clash with populists' anti-elite messaging, making such interactions politically risky. Examples abound: Yanis Varoufakis, Greece's finance minister from the left-wing populist party Syriza, famously referred to the IMF–EU bailout of Greece as "nothing short of cruel and unusual punishment" (Varoufakis 2017, 19). Similarly, Donald Trump and his supporters expressed consistent disdain for US financial support of institutions like the IMF and World Bank (Brutger and Clark 2022). Other populists, such as Venezuela's Hugo Chávez, even threatened to exit the IMF altogether.[2]

Despite their rhetoric, populists may find it difficult to entirely avoid the IMF's support because of its critical role in mitigating balance-of-payments crises as global lender of last resort. This makes their participation a particularly stringent test of our theory: Populists' being systematically less likely to engage with the IMF even when their countries face severe economic distress underscores their broader reluctance to cooperate with IOs.

In this analysis, our dependent variable is IMF program initiation, which we code for the first year that a program begins. This approach ensures that we exclude instances where leaders inherit ongoing programs. The data needed to construct this measure come from Kentikelenis, Stubbs, and King (2016), and our primary independent variable is a binary measure of populist leadership derived from Funke, Schularick, and Trebesch (2023). This comprehensive dataset of global populism classifies more than 1,500 leaders between 1900 and 2020 as populist or nonpopulist, based on their alignment with the core tenets of populist ideology—whether or not leaders purport to represent the "true, common people" against "corrupt elites." We choose this